Joy Requires Reduced Action Coupling

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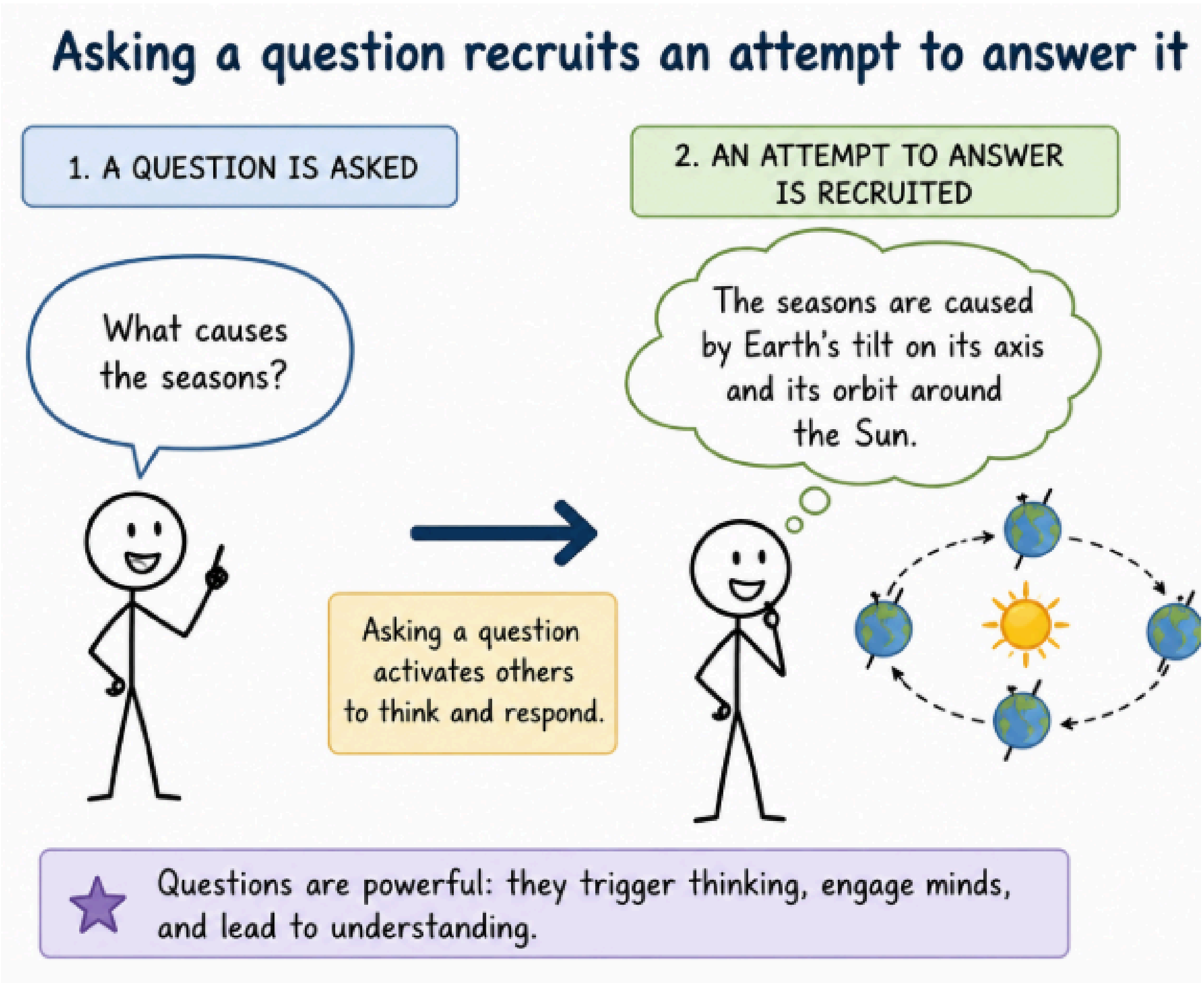
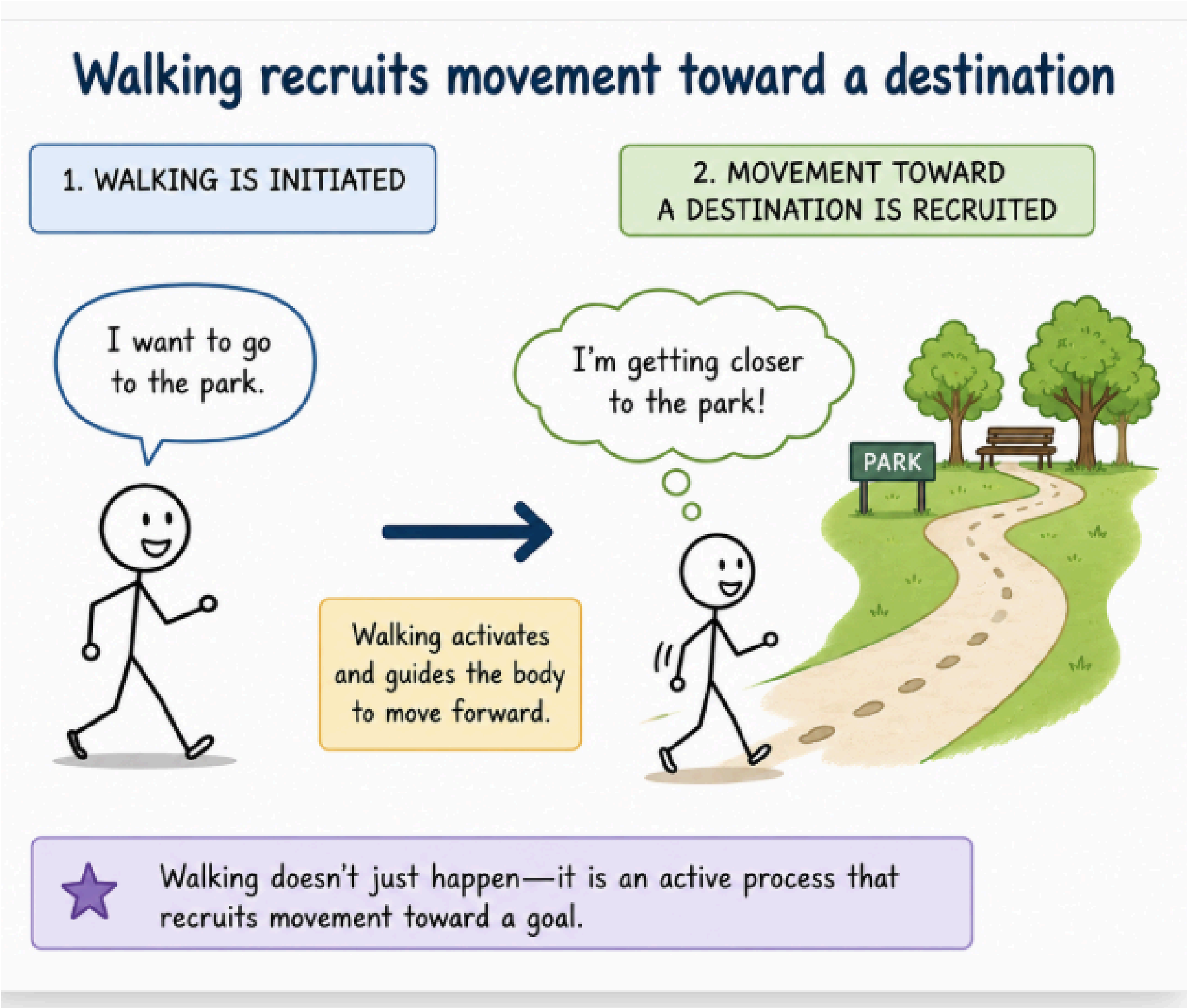
A Regime Theory of Joy

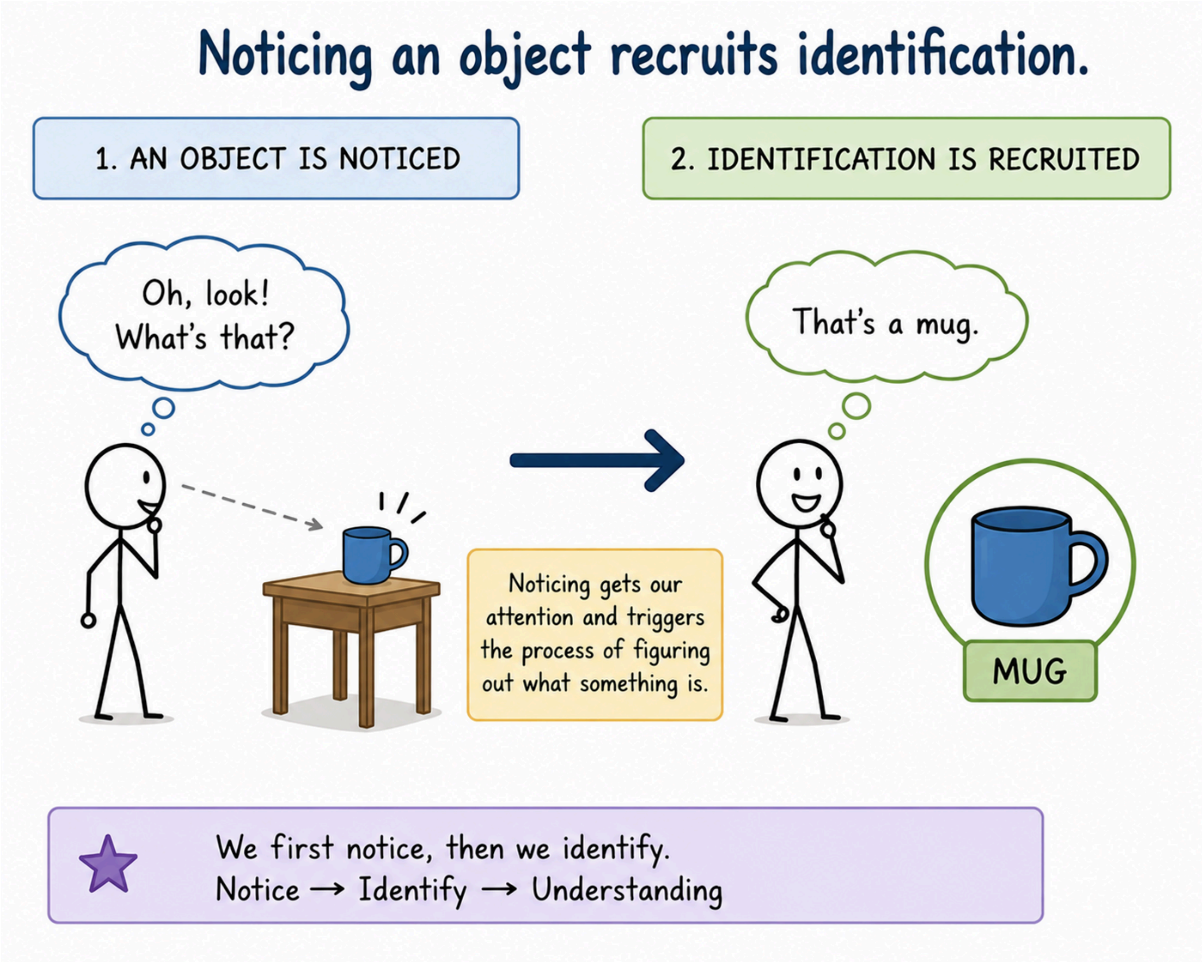
Action coupling

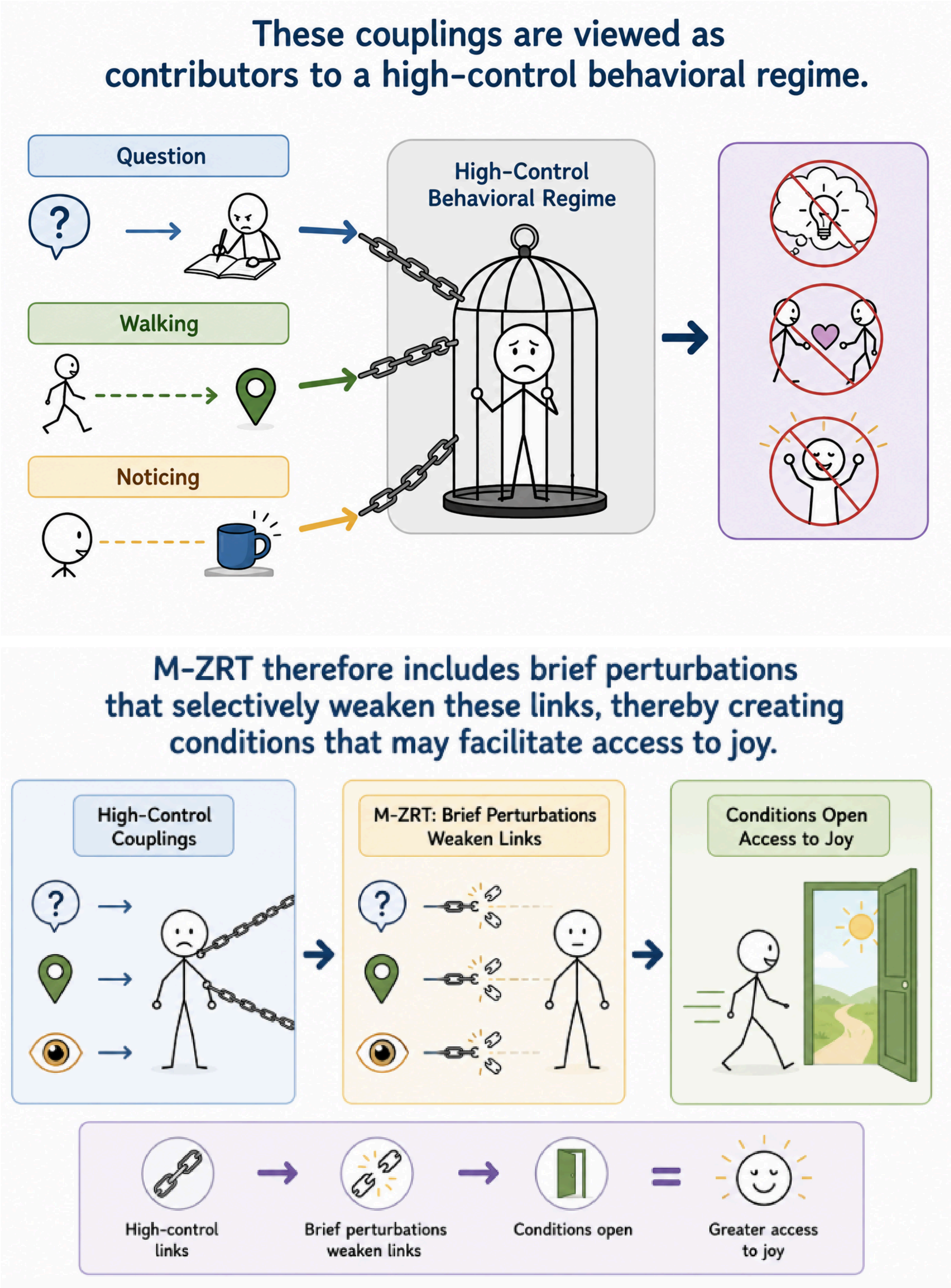
Action coupling refers to the tendency for one action to automatically recruit another.

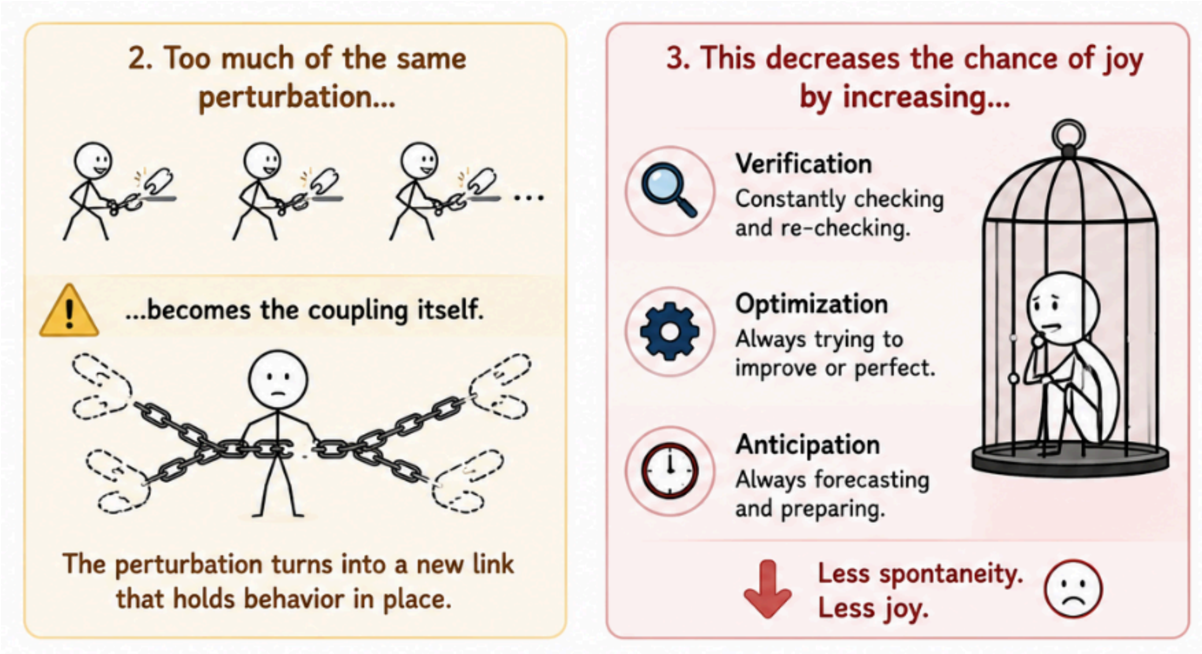
Originality of the framework. To our knowledge, this is the first framework to propose action coupling as the primary variable governing access to joy and to derive a systematic set of behavioral perturbations from that principle.




Walking recruits movement toward a destination
1. WALKING IS INITIATED
2. MOVEMENT TOWARD A DESTINATION IS RECRUITED
I want to go to the park.
I'm getting closer to the park!
PARK
Walking activates and guides the body to move forward.
Walking doesn't just happen—it is an active process that recruits movement toward a goal.


Noticing an object recruits identification.
1. AN OBJECT IS NOTICED
2. IDENTIFICATION IS RECRUITED
Oh, look! What's that?
That's a mug.
Noticing gets our attention and triggers the process of figuring out what something is.
MUG
We first notice, then we identify.
Notice → Identify → Understanding


These couplings are viewed as contributors to a high-control behavioral regime.
Question
Walking
Noticing
High-Control Behavioral Regime
M-ZRT therefore includes brief perturbations that selectively weaken these links, thereby creating conditions that may facilitate access to joy.
High-Control Couplings
M-ZRT: Brief Perturbations Weaken Links
Conditions Open Access to Joy
High-control links
Brief perturbations weaken links
Conditions open
Greater access to joy



The goal of the M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task, where Z denotes evaluative load) is to reduce the coupling between an action and its expected next action.

Examples include asking a question without attempting to answer it, or making a purposeless detour while walking.

Consider the exercise "Ask a question without answering it." Now imagine that, immediately afterward, you check whether you successfully avoided answering. From an action-policy coupling perspective, this is a failure, because the exercise has become coupled to a verification policy.

Instead of the sequence ending with an unanswered question, it now continues as:

Ask question → avoid answering → verify success.

The verification step becomes the new expected action recruited by the exercise. The behavioral sequence has crystallized into a rule that recruits evaluation whenever the exercise is performed.

The objective is therefore not to "succeed" at leaving questions unanswered, but to prevent the exercise itself from reliably recruiting any particular next action, including checking whether it worked. The exercise should terminate naturally, without requiring evaluation, or completion.

We can now compare two formulations of what appears to be the same exercise and examine how each may influence next action pressure.

1. Ask a question without answering it.

This formulation explicitly instructs the participant to perform two actions: generate a question and avoid answering it. While simple, it can recruit an additional action policy centered on monitoring whether the instruction has been followed. The sequence may become:

Ask a question → avoid answering → check whether I successfully avoided answering.

The participant may repeatedly evaluate whether they are "doing it correctly." Because each evaluation can recruit verification, error detection, and corrective adjustments, it generates additional candidate actions, thereby increasing next action pressure.

2. Small Curiosity

Let a small curiosity arise, such as "Why this color?" or "What if I turned left?" Do not try to answer it.

"Let a curiosity arise" frames the question as something that appears rather than something that must be deliberately produced. Likewise, "Do not *try* to answer it" avoids implying that success must later be verified. As a result, the cognitive sequence is more likely to terminate naturally after the question appears, without recruiting an additional verification policy.

Although both formulations describe a similar observable behavior, they may differ substantially in the amount of next action pressure they generate.

We will now use this reasoning to explore how to reduce next action pressure in an RPG video game by remaining within the game's town and avoiding combat and quests, since both naturally increase next action pressure.

Appendix 1. Lowering Next-Action Pressure With 3 Types of Exercices

Figure 1. Openness, suspension, and salience exercises all reduce next-action pressure through complementary mechanisms, creating conditions more compatible with the emergence of joy.

Because movement in RPGs is typically organized around reaching destinations, simply beginning to walk recruits planning several steps ahead. This coupling can increase next action pressure by continuously generating expectations about where to go next.

While moving through the game world, change direction for no apparent reason. Avoid choosing the "best" moment. This reintroduces prediction and verification processes, increasing next action pressure instead of reducing it.

Because text frequently appears, it naturally recruits interpretation and decision-making. Sometimes, when text appears, read it without trying to extract its meaning. Let it remain as a sequence of words rather than information that must be understood. Within the same logic, you may observe an object as if it had no predefined function,

Suspension exercises that involve refraining from prediction or information extraction are relatively straightforward to understand from an action-policy perspective. There is less basis for evaluating an imminent action, thereby reducing next action pressure over the following moments. The following figure presents the "Don't imagine what's behind an obstacle or corridor" exercise, when one simply refrains from mental simulation.

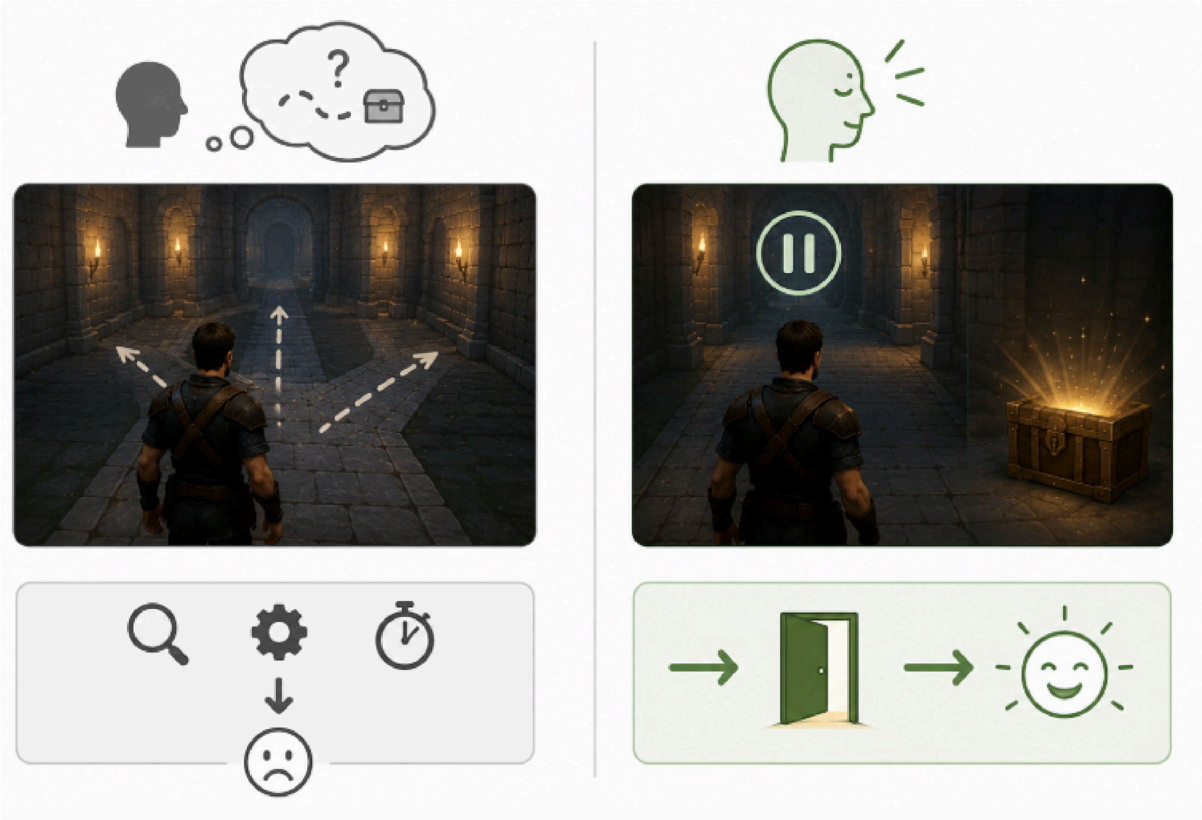


Figure 2: By momentarily interrupting anticipatory simulation (right), the exercise reduces next action pressure, allowing movement to proceed with less pre-planning.

This reduction is not guaranteed, however. If the participant begins monitoring whether the exercise is being performed correctly, or treats successful non-prediction as a goal to achieve, the exercise itself becomes a new action policy and recreates the same anticipatory control it was intended to weaken. To illustrate these principles more concretely, we now examine the following perturbation in detail: refraining from imagining what lies behind a visible obstacle before continuing naturally.

Checking whether imagination has really stopped introduces verification, requiring continuous evaluation of the current mental state. Trying to suppress the image recruits active control, creating an additional goal that must be maintained. Repeating the exercise at every corridor allows the perturbation itself to become a stable action policy. Extending the interruption longer than necessary shifts attention toward maintaining the exercise instead of allowing movement to continue naturally. Finally, mentally congratulating oneself for succeeding retrospectively evaluates the action, reinforcing performance monitoring and increasing the likelihood that future attempts will be guided by successful execution rather than by the spontaneous weakening of the original coupling.

Redistribute Salience

In most game environments, salience is not distributed uniformly. Rare items, enemies, objectives, health indicators, and other task-relevant elements automatically attract attention because they predict useful actions. Perception therefore becomes organized around behavioral value.

Salience exercises perturb that organization by assigning greater perceptual importance to an irrelevant element. For example, look at one arbitrary inventory slot, occupied or empty, as though it deserved special attention for a few seconds. Or, pick up a completely ordinary item (e.g. low-level potion) and treat it as if it were the most remarkable object in the inventory.

From the perspective of action-policy coupling, the exercise reduces the reliability of the mapping between "stands out" and "requires action." Normally, increased salience recruits inspection, evaluation, or action selection. By making an irrelevant object temporarily salient without acting on it, the participant experiences salience independently of behavioral demand, lowering the tendency for attention to immediately recruit the next action.

Interrupt the Thought

Once a planning or evaluative thought begins, each subsequent thought tends to follow predictably from the previous one, progressively narrowing the range of possible future actions. This creates an increasingly stable cognitive trajectory that recruits planning, optimization, and action selection.

Whenever you notice yourself thinking about the game, the current situation, the exercise, or anything else, end the thought with a few unrelated, meaningless words, for example, "blue, car, sky." Then continue playing normally.

Introducing a few unrelated, meaningless words briefly disrupts this trajectory. Because the inserted words have no semantic relationship to the ongoing thought, they reduce its momentum without replacing it with another goal-directed sequence. The interruption acts as a temporary break in the normal progression from one cognitive state to the next.

Equal Options

When two options appear, briefly treat them as equally acceptable. For example, two corridors, two items, two inventory slots, or two nearby NPCs. Do not compare them, rank them, or search for the better one. Let both options remain equally valid for a few seconds, then choose one normally or continue moving.

The point of this **openness exercise** is to weaken the automatic conversion of perception into optimization. If both options are allowed to be equally acceptable, the mind has less reason to extract extra information, or build next-action pressure.

Instead of allowing the thought to unfold into increasingly specific predictions and action plans, the sequence is briefly destabilized before normal activity resumes. Therefore, the exercise weakens the coupling between an emerging thought and the policy it would ordinarily recruit.

Florian Morin proposes that joy is gated by evaluative monitoring: joy does not simply fade, it becomes inaccessible when monitoring and optimization remain active.

Morin, Florian, A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration (May 03, 2026). Available at SSRN: https://ssrn.com/abstract=6711318 or http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318